

D036

Practicum in Educational Leadership

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A practicum candidate at a school with a new bus loop is supervising lunch when two students get into a shoving match. After separating them and checking for injuries, she thinks a two-day suspension is appropriate. Her cooperating principal is at a district meeting. The candidate has ten years of teaching experience. What should she do?

- A. Do nothing until next week, since she can never act on discipline.
- B. Issue it, since her teaching experience qualifies her.
- C. Issue the suspension herself, since the principal is away.
- D. Document the facts, keep the students supervised, and refer the decision to the principal or the designated administrator on site.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A cooperating principal asks a practicum candidate to lead the planning of a family literacy night. Which decision can the candidate most appropriately make on her own?

- A. Choosing the event's activities and schedule with the planning team.
- B. Signing a contract that commits school funds without approval.
- C. Every decision, since she was delegated the event.
- D. Assigning a teacher's formal evaluation rating based on the event.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

During the practicum, a candidate sits in on a meeting about a student's mental health crisis. That evening, at a crowded restaurant with friends who are also teachers at other schools, the conversation turns to hard cases. What should the candidate do?

- A. Share it without the student's name.
- B. Share it, because the friends are also educators.
- C. Keep the case confidential, and in coursework describe it only in de-identified terms.
- D. Share it to get advice, since advice helps the student.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A candidate is asked to redesign the school's arrival procedures. She has a background in logistics from a previous career and a detailed plan in mind. The school has a new marquee sign. When should she involve teachers, bus drivers, and families?

- A. After the plan is finished, to announce it on the marquee.
- B. Only teachers, since they are staff.
- C. Early, while defining the problem and options, so their knowledge shapes the design.
- D. Never, because her logistics background is enough.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

An upset parent arrives at the front office, which was just remodeled, demanding that the candidate change a teacher's decision to keep her son in from recess. She has not spoken with the teacher. The candidate is covering the office. What should the candidate do first?

- A. Show the parent the renovated office to ease tension.
- B. Listen fully, then arrange for the parent to talk with the teacher, offering support and a follow-up.
- C. Tell the parent the teacher's decision is final and end the conversation.
- D. Overrule the teacher to calm the parent.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A parent already met with the teacher about a grading concern and is still unsatisfied. What is the candidate's appropriate role now?

- A. Gather facts from the parent and teacher, review the grading policy, and involve the supervising administrator in a follow-up meeting.
- B. Tell the parent nothing more can be done.
- C. Change the grade to resolve the matter.
- D. Send the parent back to the teacher again.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

At 8:05 a.m., a candidate has three messages: a teacher needs copies for a 9:00 class, a district office wants a survey returned today, and a custodian reports a broken exterior door that won't lock near the playground. The candidate's coffee is getting cold. What should she handle first?

- A. Make the teacher's copies, since class starts soonest.
- B. Secure or supervise the broken exterior door and notify the administrator.
- C. Handle them in the order received.
- D. Complete the district survey, since it is due today.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A candidate has no safety issues pending. Which task should she schedule for later or delegate?

- A. Covering a class whose teacher went home sick.
- B. Meeting a student in crisis waiting in the counseling office.
- C. Nothing can ever be delegated in a practicum.
- D. Reorganizing the office supply closet.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A candidate writes in her practicum log: "Today I led the PLC meeting in the newly painted library. We discussed data. It went well." The meeting lasted 45 minutes. How should she strengthen the reflection?

- A. Write a longer summary of the agenda.
- B. Add more detail about the room.
- C. Leave it; any log entry counts as reflection.
- D. Analyze specific evidence of what worked or not, connect it to a leadership standard, and name one change for next time.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

With her supervisor's approval, a candidate must address a teacher who has arrived 15 minutes late to morning duty four times this month, leaving students unsupervised. The teacher is popular and runs the school's new robotics club. Where and how should the conversation happen?

- A.** At the next staff meeting, reminding everyone about duty.
- B.** Let it go, since the teacher is popular.
- C.** Privately and soon, stating the four dates, the effect on student supervision, the expectation going forward, and agreed next steps.
- D.** In front of the students on duty, so the lesson is clear.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher responds to a candidate's concern by saying, "You're always picking on me." What is the best reply?

- A.** Stay calm, acknowledge the feeling, and return to the specific observed facts and the expectation.
- B.** Drop the concern to avoid conflict.
- C.** List other complaints about the teacher.
- D.** Tell the teacher feelings never matter in these talks.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

Attendance at evening family meetings is low at a school where many parents work second shifts and speak Vietnamese. The meetings are held in a newly redesigned auditorium. A staff member says, "These parents just don't care." What should the candidate propose?

- A.** Send an English flyer home with students.
- B.** Ask families about better times and formats, offer interpretation, and hold some meetings at community locations or online.
- C.** Hold the same meeting more often in the auditorium.
- D.** Agree that the families do not care and stop holding meetings.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A practicum candidate ~~at a school with a new bus loop~~ is supervising lunch when two students get into a shoving match. After separating them and checking for injuries, she thinks a two-day suspension is appropriate. Her cooperating principal is at a district meeting. ~~The candidate has ten years of teaching experience.~~ What should she do?

Target word: action within authority **Decides:** Suspension is an administrator's decision; she gathers facts and consults.

A	Absolute language	She should act on safety and facts now, just not the formal decision.
B	Camouflage	Experience does not grant administrative authority.
C	Inverted operation	Takes a decision reserved for a licensed administrator.
D	Correct	She acts within delegated authority and routes the formal decision properly.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

A cooperating principal asks a practicum candidate to lead the planning of a family literacy night. Which decision can the candidate most appropriately make on her own?

Target word: a decision within delegated scope **Decides:** Tasks inside the delegated project are hers to lead.

A	Correct	Within the project the principal delegated.
B	Inverted operation	Financial commitments need administrator approval.
C	Absolute language	Delegation has limits.
D	Adjacent category	Evaluation is reserved to licensed administrators.

3. Answer C Concept 2

During the practicum, a candidate sits in on a meeting about a student's mental health crisis. That evening, at a ~~crowded~~ restaurant with friends ~~who are also teachers at other schools~~, the conversation turns to hard cases. What should the candidate do?

Target word: handling confidential information **Decides:** No need to know; do not share.

A	Dropped element	Details can still identify a student; there is no need to know.
B	Camouflage	Being educators does not create a need to know.
C	Correct	Information is shared only with those who need to know.
D	Adjacent category	Consultation belongs with the supervisor or team, not friends.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A candidate is asked to redesign the school's arrival procedures. She has a background in logistics from a previous career and a detailed plan in mind. ~~The school has a new marquee sign.~~ When should she involve teachers, bus drivers, and families?

Target word: when to involve stakeholders **Decides:** Involve affected people early.

A	Inverted operation	Asks for input only after decisions are made.
B	Dropped element	Leaves out drivers and families, who are directly affected.
C	Correct	Early collaboration improves the plan and builds ownership.
D	Camouflage	Her expertise does not replace stakeholder knowledge.

5. Answer B Concept 4

An upset parent arrives at the front office, ~~which was just remodeled~~, demanding that the candidate change a teacher's decision to keep her son in from recess. She has not spoken with the teacher. The candidate is covering the office. What should the candidate do first?

Target word: first step **Decides:** Listen, then connect the parent with the teacher first.

A	Camouflage	Irrelevant to the concern.
B	Correct	Concerns start at the closest level, with support and follow-up.
C	Absolute language	Dismisses the concern without listening.
D	Inverted operation	Bypasses the teacher and promises an outcome without facts.

6. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

A parent already met with the teacher about a grading concern and is still unsatisfied. What is the candidate's appropriate role now?

Target word: next level of response **Decides:** The concern moves up with facts gathered from both sides.

A	Correct	The concern moves to the next level with facts and proper authority.
B	Absolute language	Families have routes to escalate concerns.
C	Adjacent category	Not the candidate's decision, and no facts reviewed yet.
D	Inverted operation	The first level has already been tried.

7. Answer B Concept 5

At 8:05 a.m., a candidate has three messages: a teacher needs copies for a 9:00 class, a district office wants a survey returned today, and a custodian reports a broken exterior door that won't lock near the playground. ~~The candidate's coffee is getting cold.~~ What should she handle first?

Target word: first priority **Decides:** The unlocked exterior door is an immediate safety risk.

A	Adjacent category	Urgent but not a safety risk.
B	Correct	Safety comes before everything else.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out any prioritization.
D	Confusion set	Due today is not more urgent than safety.

8. Answer D Concept 5 • transfer

A candidate has no safety issues pending. Which task should she schedule for later or delegate?

Target word: task to defer **Decides:** Not urgent and not tied to immediate student needs.

A	Confusion set	Students need supervision now.
B	Inverted operation	Urgent and important; handle now.
C	Absolute language	Candidates may delegate within their role.
D	Correct	Low urgency; can be scheduled or delegated.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A candidate writes in her practicum log: "Today I led the PLC meeting ~~in the newly painted library~~. We discussed data. It went well." ~~The meeting lasted 45 minutes.~~ How should she strengthen the reflection?

Target word: stronger reflection **Decides:** Analysis against evidence and standards, plus a next step.

A	Adjacent category	More description, still no analysis.
B	Camouflage	Setting is not analysis.
C	Absolute language	Description alone is not reflection.
D	Correct	Reflection moves from description to analysis and action.

10. Answer C Concept 7

With her supervisor's approval, a candidate must address a teacher who has arrived 15 minutes late to morning duty four times this month, leaving students unsupervised. ~~The teacher is popular and runs the school's new robotics club.~~ Where and how should the conversation happen?

Target word: how to raise the concern **Decides:** Private, prompt, fact-based, with clear expectations.

A	Adjacent category	A general reminder avoids the individual issue.
B	Camouflage	Popularity does not reduce the safety concern.
C	Correct	Specific, private and focused on students.
D	Inverted operation	Public correction damages trust.

11. Answer A Concept 7 · transfer

A teacher responds to a candidate's concern by saying, "You're always picking on me." What is the best reply?

Target word: response to defensiveness **Decides:** Return calmly to the specific facts and the student effect.

A	Correct	Keeps the conversation fact-based and focused on students.
B	Inverted operation	Avoidance leaves the problem in place.
C	Adjacent category	Broadens the conversation and escalates it.
D	Absolute language	Acknowledging feelings helps keep the talk productive.

12. Answer B Concept 8

Attendance at evening family meetings is low at a school where many parents work second shifts and speak Vietnamese. The meetings are held ~~in a newly redesigned auditorium~~. A staff member says, "These parents just don't care." What should the candidate propose?

Target word: engagement plan **Decides:** Meet families where they are and build on strengths.

A	Dropped element	Leaves out the language and schedule barriers.
B	Correct	Asset-based engagement removes barriers and invites two-way exchange.
C	Camouflage	Answers the venue detail and repeats the barrier.
D	Inverted operation	Deficit thinking misreads barriers as lack of interest.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	9	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	7	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	2	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Acting within delegated authority	A practicum candidate leads real tasks but only within the authority the supervising administrator delegates; decisions reserved to licensed administrators, such as formal discipline or evaluation, go through the supervisor.	Making a binding administrative decision alone because it seems obvious or the supervisor is busy.	A decision that normally requires an administrator's authority.
2	Confidentiality in the field	Student and staff information learned during the practicum is shared only with those who have a legitimate need to know, and is de-identified in coursework.	Discussing identifiable cases with friends, colleagues outside the matter, or in assignments.	Sensitive information and a setting where others could hear or read it.
3	Collaborating with stakeholders	Involve the people affected by a decision (teachers, staff, families, students, community partners) early, and align partnerships with the school's goals.	Designing a plan alone and asking for input only after it is finished.	A new initiative and a question about who to involve and when.
4	Handling a family concern	Listen fully, gather facts from all sides, direct the concern to the closest appropriate level first (usually the teacher) with support, and follow up.	Promising an outcome on the spot or bypassing the teacher without cause.	A parent arrives upset about a classroom decision.
5	Prioritizing duties: safety first	When demands compete, act first on immediate safety, then on urgent and important tasks tied to students, and schedule or delegate the rest.	Handling tasks in the order they arrive or by who is asking loudest.	Several demands at once, one involving a safety risk.
6	Reflective practice	Reflection examines an action against evidence and leadership standards, names what worked and what did not, and sets a specific adjustment for next time.	Writing a description of what happened with no analysis or next step.	A practicum log entry to evaluate.
7	Difficult conversations with staff	Address a performance or conduct concern privately and promptly, describe specific observed facts and their effect on students, state clear expectations, and agree on next steps.	Addressing it publicly, speaking only in generalities, or avoiding it.	A staff concern and a choice of how and where to raise it.
8	Asset-based community engagement	Engage families and community as partners by building on their strengths, meeting them where they are (times, places, languages), and creating two-way exchange.	Assuming low turnout means families do not care, and repeating the same event format.	Low participation and a plan to change it.

Course scope (public description): Focus on Professional Practices - Practicum in Educational Leadership - Focus on Professional Practices provides candidates with an authentic, real-world work experience as an educational leader in a K-12 school environment. This is the first of a two-part experience designed to take place under the leadership and supervision of a practicing school principal or assistant principal at an approved practicum school site (K-12). This course includes an emphasis on the application of knowledge and skills to areas directly or indirectly affecting students. Collaboration within the school and local community is a focal point for this course. The course also includes the completion of assigned administrative duties in a K-12 setting, as defined by the candidate's state of residence, under the supervision of the cooperating administrator of the candidate's approved practicum site. Prior to enrolling in this practicum course, the candidate must complete a minimum of 18 CUs.